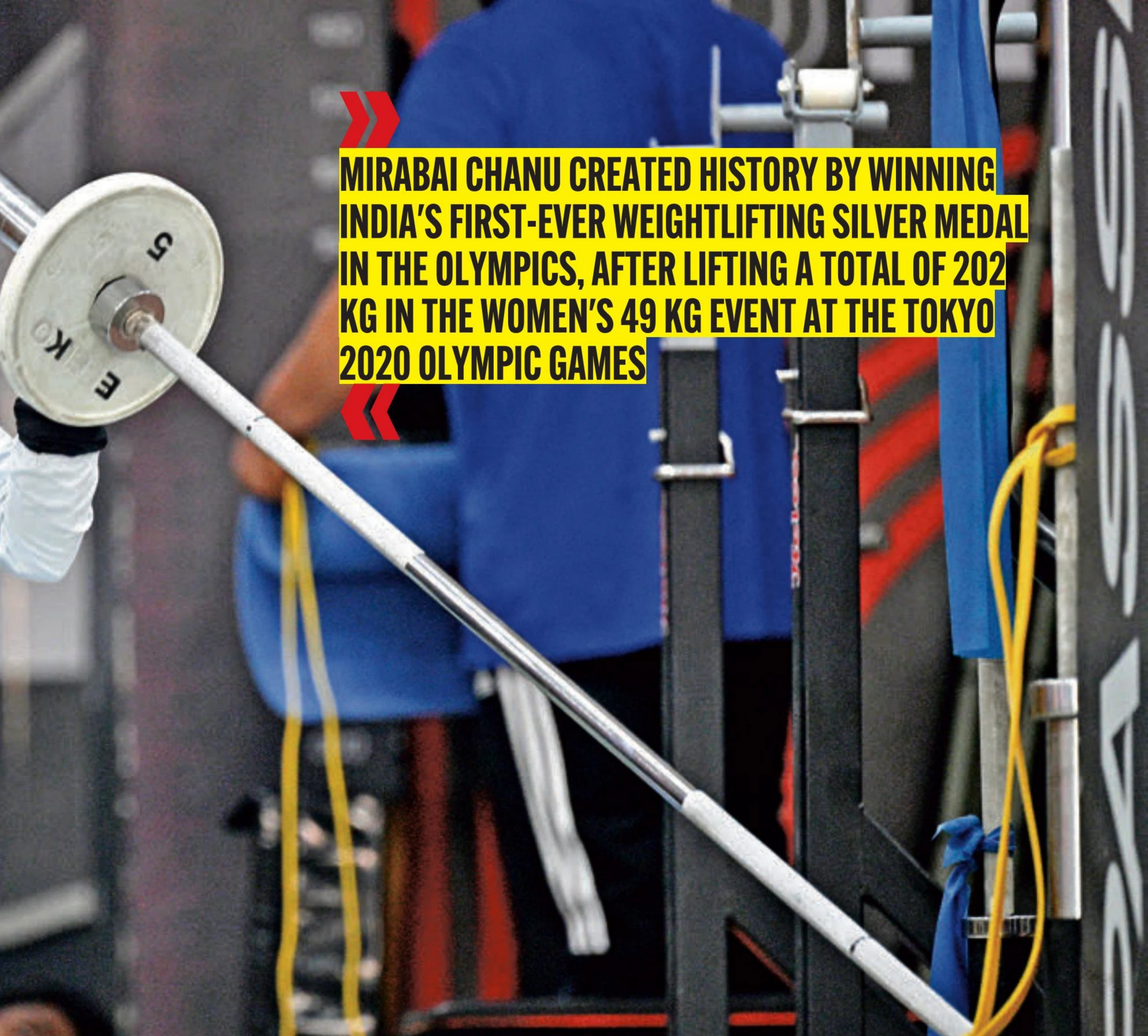




MIRABAI CHANU CREATED HISTORY BY WINNING INDIA'S FIRST-EVER WEIGHTLIFTING SILVER MEDAL IN THE OLYMPICS, AFTER LIFTING A TOTAL OF 202 KG IN THE WOMEN'S 49 KG EVENT AT THE TOKYO 2020 OLYMPIC GAMES

Difficult shift

The move to the 53kg division will be challenging. At 4'11, Mirabai will not find it easy to add the additional 5kg of muscle mass, more than 10 per cent of her body weight, that she will need.

The level of competition will also be higher. At last year's World Championships, the bronze-medal total was 200kg, compared to 198kg in the women's 48kg category. The number could have been higher had China's Du Meiyuan not withdrawn due to injury.

Additionally, many of her competitors have already been

preparing for the 53kg category, while Mirabai will only transition after the Commonwealth Games.

Yet, she isn't overly concerned. Lifting 205kg at her current body weight gives her confidence that she can lift more with additional muscle.

She is, in fact, looking forward to one aspect of the transition.

"I've been 48–49kg for many years. One of the hardest things was constantly controlling what I ate. It took a lot of motivation to remind myself why I was doing it.

"After the Tokyo Olympics, Domino's gave me a free pizza-for-life deal, but I never really

used it because I couldn't eat it! So one thing I'm looking forward to is eating a bit more," she says.

For now, she remains focused. At 31, she knows she is in the latter stages of her career, but she is determined to push as long as she can.

"People say that in sport you start deteriorating with age. That may be true. But I believe motivation matters just as much. Every competition motivates me. It shows me the way forward and reminds me of the work I've put in over the years.

"As long as I have that motivation, I'll keep fighting," she says.